

Fowl Play — Arcade Game 11 Design Document (the Slop shelf)

Oct 5, 2026 · @Phillip Argall

Overview

Fowl Play is a 1-6 player first-person 3D bird-shooting competition on the Deep Arcade's Slop shelf, built on the bones of the classic NES light-gun duck shooter. Players stand in a row of stalls on a covered shooting porch overlooking a marsh, birds are released over the field, and everyone shoots at the same sky. Between hunts there are 45 seconds to walk the room behind the stalls: buy guns and attachments, spin the mystery-gun machine, gamble winnings at slots and scratchers, and visit the Slop Shop for cosmetics and dirty tricks to use on everyone else.

What it takes from the light-gun classic: the marsh, the reeds, the flushed birds flying up and away, the round-by-round escalation, the hit counter at the bottom of the screen, the dog who retrieves your birds (and laughs at your misses), and the plastic toy gun. **What it adds:** a real 3D space shared by six players, money, an arsenal of 30 guns built in that same toy style, gambling, and sabotage.

The look of the guns. Every gun in the game is drawn as a chunky toy light-gun version of itself: two-tone grey moulded plastic (a lighter grey body over a darker grey barrel and grip), a ribbed grip, a stubby red trigger, a ribbed slide on top, visible screw bosses, and a red maker's stamp on the side (an invented brand, the "Zappa" logo, never a real one). A shotgun is a toy shotgun in grey and red; a gatling gun is a toy gatling gun; the ray gun is a toy ray gun. Real gun types keep their real silhouettes so players can recognize them; the plastic is the joke and the identity.

Design pillars

1. **One sky, six guns.** Everyone shoots the same birds, so every shot is a race and every kill is stolen from somebody.
2. **Money changes everything.** Birds pay; the intermission spends; the arsenal and the gambling decide who's ahead by round 10.
3. **Slop with craft.** Crab cannons and pigeon decoys, but the shooting feels tight and the economy is balanced enough to compete on.

4. **Grief is a feature.** The Slop Shop sells ways to ruin your friends' rounds, and every one has a counter.

Session. 15 rounds, about 25 minutes. 1–6 players (bots fill). Score pays arcade tokens.

The match

A match is 15 rounds. Each round is a **hunt** (60 seconds of birds) followed by an **intermission** (45 seconds in the room). The leader after round 15 by **birds shot** wins; money is how you get there, not the score.

Phase	Length	What happens
Hunt	60 s	Players are locked to their stalls (they can step left and right inside their stall, crouch, and lean). Birds are released in waves from the reeds; everyone shoots. The dog flushes and retrieves
Tally	5 s	The dog holds up each player's birds; the board updates; money is paid
Intermission	45 s	The stall gates open and players walk the room: the gun counter, the mystery-gun machine, slots, scratchers, the Slop Shop. A bell at 10 s; at 0 the gates pull everyone back to their stalls

Escalation

Rounds	Birds per wave	Waves	Speed	New birds
1–3	2	6	Slow	Mallards, teal
4–6	3	7	Medium	Geese, pigeons, the first golden duck
7–9	4	8	Fast	Crows, armored ducks, decoy flocks
10–12	5	8	Fast, erratic	Swans, ducklings in convoy, the phoenix
13–15	6	9	Very fast	Everything; round 15 is the Golden Hour (all bird values doubled)

Winning

- **Birds shot** is the score (each bird counts once, credited to whoever fired the killing shot; specials count more, see Birds).
- **Money** comes from birds (by species) and from gambling; it buys guns, attachments, and Slop. A player can lead in money and lose on birds.
- Ties break on accuracy.
- **Perfect wave:** shooting every bird of a wave before anyone else does pays a bonus and a crowd cheer.

The range

The whole game is one building and the marsh in front of it: the **Fowl Play Gun Club**, a timber clubhouse with a long covered porch facing a marsh at dusk.

The porch: six stalls

- Six stalls side by side along the porch rail, 3 m wide each, divided by waist-high wooden partitions so everyone can see everyone. Each stall has a numbered post, a hook for spare guns, an ammo tray, and a little scoreboard flap.
- The marsh in front is 200 m wide and 150 m deep: reeds at the near edge (where birds flush), open water, a few dead trees, a hill at the back where the sun sets, and a treeline. Birds fly across the whole field, so a bird on the far left is reachable from stall

6, just harder.

- With fewer than six players, the empty stalls hold cardboard cutout hunters (and bots, if chosen).

The room behind the porch

A single open clubhouse room, 30 m by 15 m, reached through the stall gates:

Area	What's there
The gun counter	A glass case of guns and a pegboard of attachments; the shopkeeper (a toy-gun-shaped robot called Mr. Zappa)
The mystery-gun machine	A big red gumball-machine-shaped crank that dispenses a random gun in a capsule
The slot row	Six slot machines along the back wall, so nobody waits
The scratch-off counter	A dispenser and a counter with coins on strings
The Slop Shop	A garish booth with a neon sign, run by a raccoon in a vest
The trophy wall	Every player's best round so far and the club records
The bar	Cosmetic only; nothing for sale; the dog sleeps under it

The dog

The club dog (a scruffy hunting hound) flushes birds from the reeds at the start of each wave, runs out to retrieve kills, and holds them up at the tally. When a whole wave escapes, it pops up and laughs, as tradition demands. It can be shot. It can't be hurt (shots bounce off with a squeak), but shooting the dog costs the shooter one bird from their score and the dog remembers: next round it retrieves that player's birds last.

Birds

Birds flush from the reeds in waves, fly a pattern across and away over the marsh, and escape off the far edge after 6–10 seconds if nobody hits them. Every bird has HP (most die to one pistol shot), a pattern, a bird count toward the score, and a payout.

Bird	From round	HP	Pattern	Counts as	Pays
Mallard	1	1	Rises, zigzags twice, flies off	1	\$10
Teal	1	1	Low and fast along the water	1	\$12
Goose	4	3	Slow, straight, high; honks	1	\$25
Pigeon	4	1	Flocks of 5 that scatter when one is hit	1	\$5 each
Golden Duck	4 (1 per round)	2	Very fast, erratic, glints	3	\$100
Crow	7	1	Dives at the porch, then away (it can knock a hat off)	1	\$15
Armored Duck	7	4	A duck in a tiny helmet; shots to the body ping off, the belly is the weak point	2	\$40
Decoy Flock	7	1	Wooden decoys that fly; shooting one costs \$10 (they're club property)	0	–\$10
Swan	10	6	Graceful, slow, enormous; hitting it angers it (it flies at the porch and bites a random player's gun, jamming it 3 s)	2	\$60
Duckling Convoy	10	1 each	A mother duck (3 HP) leads six ducklings; shooting the mother scatters the ducklings; shooting ducklings boos you	1 each, the mother 2	\$5 each, \$30
Phoenix	10 (rare)	8	Fiery, loops, explodes into three small fire birds when killed	5	\$250
Clay Pigeon	Any (bonus waves)	1	Launched from traps in arcs, no flapping	1	\$8
The Turkey	13	10	Runs along the ground through the reeds; does not fly	3	\$150
UFO	15 (once)	20	A flying saucer abducts a wave of ducks; shoot it to free them (each freed duck is a free kill for the shooter)	5	\$500

Bonus waves

Once every three rounds, a 10 s **bonus wave** of clay pigeons fires from traps at the end of the porch. Everybody's guns are swapped for the classic grey pistol for the bonus; it's a pure aim contest.

Kill credit

The killing shot gets the bird. Damage from other players' shots isn't shared, so a goose softened by one player is stolen by another, which is the point.

Shooting

- **Aim:** mouse or stick, first person, with the gun visible in hand. No aim assist. Each gun has a small sway and a recoil kick in its own direction.
- **Light-gun feel:** every shot flashes the screen for a frame (a nod to the old light-gun trick), the hit spark is a white square, and a hit bird freezes for a beat with a surprised face before falling. Misses kick up a puff of feathers or water.
- **Ammo:** each gun has a magazine and reserve; ammo is refilled free at the start of each hunt; a few guns need ammo bought (noted). Reloading is a big chunky animation (the toy guns' magazines are oversized plastic boxes).
- **Range:** every gun hits anywhere on the field, but accuracy falls off with distance per gun.
- **Friendly fire:** shooting another player does nothing to them (it's a toy gun), but shooting their hat knocks it off, and some fun guns push.
- **Accuracy** is tracked and shown; it's the tiebreak and a few attachments reward it.
- **Money** is paid at the tally for each bird and kept between rounds.

The arsenal

Thirty guns, all in the toy light-gun style (two-tone grey plastic, ribbed grip, red trigger, ribbed top slide, screw bosses, the red "Zappa" stamp), each keeping the real silhouette of its type. Prices are in the club's money. A player holds two guns (swap with a key) and can store one more on the stall hook.

Real types

Gun	Type	Price	Damage	Rate	Mag	Notes
The Zapper	Pistol (starting gun)	Free	1	Semi	6	The classic; never sold, never lost
Twin Zappers	Akimbo pistols	\$120	1 each	Semi, alternating	12	Two at once; each hand aims slightly differently
Long Zapper	Revolver	\$150	3	Slow	6	One-shots geese; big kick
Pump Shotgun	Shotgun	\$200	6 pellets × 1	Pump	5	Spread; the pigeon flock's nightmare
Double Barrel	Shotgun	\$180	8 pellets × 1, ×2	Two shots then reload	2	Both barrels at once for a wide blast
Auto Shotgun	Shotgun	\$450	6 pellets	Auto	8	Expensive and greedy
Pocket SMG	SMG	\$220	1	Fast auto	30	Spray at a flock; poor at range
Tommy	SMG	\$300	1	Auto	50 (drum)	The drum is a toy biscuit tin
Carbine	Rifle	\$260	2	Semi	15	Accurate at range
Lever Rifle	Rifle	\$240	3	Lever	8	Satisfying click; good on golden ducks
Battle Rifle	Assault rifle	\$380	2	Auto	30	The all-rounder
Hunting Sniper	Sniper	\$400	10	Bolt	5	A scope; one-shots everything but the UFO
Light Machine Gun	Machine gun	\$550	1	Very fast auto	100	Pins you in place while firing (no stepping)
Belt-fed Heavy	Machine gun	\$700	2	Fast auto	150	Needs a bipod on the rail; can't turn more than 90 degrees
Flare Pistol	Utility	\$100	2 + lights the sky	Single	1	A flare lights birds (and night rounds) for everyone; buy flares

Fun guns (fifteen)

Gun	Price	What it does
Crab Cannon	\$350	Fires a live crab that clamps onto a bird and drags it down (a kill after 1 s); crabs that miss land in the marsh and walk back to your stall
Gatling Gun	\$600	A hand-cranked toy gatling: spins up for 1 s, then a firehose of plastic pellets; turning it is slow
Ray Gun	\$500	A toy ray gun that fires a slow green beam; anything in the beam is turned into a roast chicken (a kill)
Net Launcher	\$250	A weighted net that catches up to three birds in an area; they fall together
Bread Gun	\$150	Fires bread; birds that eat it fly slowly toward your stall for 3 s (easy shots, and other players can steal them)
Boomerang Blaster	\$280	A boomerang that arcs out and back, hitting everything on its path both ways; catch it or lose it
Bubble Cannon	\$220	Bubbles trap a bird and float it upward slowly for 4 s; pop it for the kill (anyone can pop it)
Magnet Gun	\$320	Pulls metal: armored ducks, the UFO, and other players' dropped guns; armored ducks are yanked to the rail
Firework Launcher	\$400	A rocket that bursts into a sky-wide spray of sparkles: a few random kills and a show
Plunger Rifle	\$180	Sticks a plunger to a bird; the bird flies erratically and slowly; a second plunger kills
Leaf Blower	\$260	Blows birds back toward the porch (they stay in the sky longer) and blows other players' hats off
Banana Bazooka	\$300	Fires a banana bunch that splits into five bananas in the air; each is a kill on a small bird

Gun	Price	What it does
The Honker	\$200	Fires a goose call; every goose and swan turns toward you for 3 s (geese become easy; swans become a problem)
Lightning Rod	\$550	A toy tesla gun; the bolt chains between birds up to five times
The Mega Zapper	\$800	An enormous version of the starting pistol, held in two hands; fires one huge shot per 3 s that kills everything in a wide cone; the screen flash is blinding (it flashes everyone's screen)

Attachments

Sold on the pegboard; each gun takes one of each slot where it fits.

Attachment	Slot	Price	Effect
Red dot	Sight	\$60	Tighter aim; a red dot
Toy scope	Sight	\$120	3× zoom on rifles and pistols
Extended mag	Magazine	\$80	+50% magazine
Drum mag	Magazine	\$150	+150% magazine, slower reload
Speed loader	Magazine	\$70	Reload twice as fast
Choke	Barrel	\$90	Tighter shotgun spread
Long barrel	Barrel	\$100	Less falloff at range
Bird-seeker sticker	Barrel	\$200	Shots curve slightly toward the nearest bird (a little)
Golden trigger	Trigger	\$250	+50% money per kill with this gun
Hair trigger	Trigger	\$90	+20% fire rate
Laser pointer	Under-barrel	\$50	A red line everyone can see (and birds can't)
Bipod	Under-barrel	\$70	Steadier when resting on the rail

Attachment	Slot	Price	Effect
Duck-call underbarrel	Under-barrel	\$150	A button to call ducks toward you once per wave (others can shoot them too)
Sticker pack	Cosmetic	\$20	Stickers on the plastic

Guns and attachments are kept for the match; nothing carries to the next match.

The intermission

Forty-five seconds, one room, six people, and everything costs money. The room is laid out so a player can do two or three things in that time, not all of them, which is the decision.

The gun counter

Walk up to the glass case: guns and attachments show on the case with price and stats; buying is one click and the gun appears in your hands. Mr. Zappa gives each player one **daily deal** per intermission (a random gun or attachment at 30% off, shown only to that player).

The mystery-gun machine

- A big red crank machine. One crank costs the price of the cheapest gun in the game (the Flare Pistol, \$100).
- It dispenses a plastic capsule with a random gun from all 30 (the Zapper excluded), equal odds. A crank can hand you the Mega Zapper for \$100, or the Bread Gun.
- The gun goes in your hands; your current second gun drops to the stall hook (or the floor if the hook is full, where anyone can take it).
- A crank at under 10 s left plays a drumroll; the capsule opens on the porch as the hunt starts.

Slot machines

- Six machines; \$10, \$25, or \$50 a pull. Three reels of ducks, dogs, guns, bells, and the Zappa logo.
- Payouts: two of a kind returns the bet; three ducks 5×; three dogs 10×; three guns pays a random gun; three bells 25×; three Zappa logos 100× and a fanfare everyone hears.

- The house edge is about 8%. Pulls take 2 s, so a player can pull about 15 times in an intermission, which is a whole intermission spent gambling.

Scratch-off tickets

Ticket	Price	Top prize	Odds of any win
Lucky Duck	\$5	\$100	1 in 3
Golden Goose	\$20	\$500	1 in 4
Gun Lottery	\$50	A random gun plus \$200	1 in 5
The Dog's Bone	\$15	The dog retrieves your birds first and sniffs out a golden duck for you next round	1 in 6
Slop Ticket	\$10	A random Slop Shop item	1 in 2

Scratching is done with the cursor (3 s a ticket) and can be pocketed to scratch on the porch between waves.

Timing

The bell at 10 s. At 0 everyone is pulled back to their stall wherever they are (a slot pull mid-spin finishes and pays). A player who bought nothing gets a small interest on cash (+5%) for patience.

The Slop Shop

A neon booth run by a raccoon in a vest. It sells two kinds of thing: **cosmetics** that last the match, and **sabotage** that ruins someone else's next hunt. Every sabotage item names a target player when bought (or "the leader" for a premium), shows on the board so everyone knows who did it, and has a counter that the target can buy or do.

Cosmetics (match-only)

A hat (cowboy, duck bill, bucket, crown) \$30; a gun paint (chrome, gold, camo, bubblegum pink) \$40; a victory dance \$25; a stall flag \$20; a dog outfit (the dog wears it while retrieving your birds) \$35; a kill sound (quack, kazoo, airhorn, sad trombone) \$30; tracer colors \$20. Permanent cosmetics are bought with arcade tokens outside the match.

Sabotage

Item	Price	Effect on the target's next hunt	Counter
Rubber Ducky Rounds	\$80	Their first magazine is squeaky rubber ducks (no damage)	Reload early (the second magazine is normal)
Butter Fingers	\$100	Their gun slips out of their hand twice during the hunt (a 2 s pickup)	A grip tape attachment (\$30)
Cardboard Sightline	\$90	A cardboard cutout of a moose stands in front of their stall for 15 s	Shoot it (3 hits)
Bee Hat	\$120	A swarm of bees around their head for 10 s; aim sways wildly	A smoke pipe (\$40)
Decoy Rain	\$70	Extra decoy ducks fly through their half of the sky (each hit costs \$10)	Look carefully: decoys have no eyes
Lens Smudge	\$60	A greasy blur on their screen for 20 s	Wipe it (hold a key 2 s)
Reverse Controls	\$150	Their horizontal aim is inverted for the first 15 s	Nothing; learn it
Loud Neighbor	\$90	A bagpiper stands in the stall beside them for the whole hunt; the audio drowns bird cues	Earplugs (\$25)
The Dog's Grudge	\$300	The dog retrieves none of their birds this round (they still count, but their money earned is halved at the end of the match, not now)	Feed the dog a sausage (\$50) before the hunt
Taxman	\$250	Takes 20% of their winnings from the next hunt and gives it to the buyer	A lawyer at the Slop Shop (\$100) returns it to sender

Item	Price	Effect on the target's next hunt	Counter
Swap Meet	\$300	Swaps their primary gun with the buyer's for the next hunt	Lock box on the stall hook (\$80)
Ghost Pepper Snack	\$60	Their screen goes red and wobbly for 10 s, then normal	Milk (\$20)
Duck Repellent	\$180	Birds avoid flying over their side of the field for 20 s	A duck call (\$40)
Glitter Bomb	\$40	Their stall is covered in glitter; purely cosmetic; it never comes off this match	None; you are sparkly now

Rules

- A player can be targeted by at most two sabotage items per hunt (the shop shows "sold out" on a third).
- Sabotage on the leader costs +50% (it's a common purchase).
- A player who buys sabotage on everyone gets the **Menace** title on the board; the bots and the dog treat them with suspicion.
- The Slop Ticket scratcher is the cheap way in.

Modes, scoring, and tokens

Mode	Rule
Open Season (default)	15 rounds; most birds wins
Quick Draw	7 rounds, 30 s intermissions
Zapper Only	Everyone keeps the starting pistol; the shop sells only attachments and Slop; pure aim
High Roller	Everyone starts with \$1,000; money is the score (birds pay, gambling counts)
Teams	3v3 or 2v2v2; team bird totals; sabotage can't target teammates

Mode	Rule
Night Shoot	Dark rounds; birds have glowing eyes; flares are essential
Mystery Box	No gun counter; the mystery-gun machine is free once per intermission
Practice	Solo, no money, any gun, any bird

End of match

A podium on the porch: first place gets the dog's trophy; the board shows birds, accuracy, money won and lost gambling, sabotage given and received, and a stat for the most expensive gun bought and how many birds it shot.

Tokens

10 per match, 1 per 5 birds, 25 for a win, 50 for a first UFO kill, 20 for a perfect wave. Tokens buy permanent cosmetics (gun paints, hats, kill sounds, dog outfits) or spin the arcade crate (the usual 40 items in four tiers; the Special tier includes the Golden Zapper, a Duck Costume for the dog, and a Mr. Zappa hat).

Presentation, technology, sound, and build order

Look

Fowl Play is bright and plastic: a low-poly marsh at golden hour, a warm timber clubhouse, and toy guns that look moulded and slightly glossy. Birds are rounded and expressive (a hit bird's eyes go wide; a falling bird spins). The HUD is a chunky 8-bit-style strip along the bottom (round number, bullets as little icons, birds as little silhouettes that fill as they're hit), a love letter to the old screen, rendered crisp. This look is Fowl Play's own.

Technology

- First-person 3D on the arcade's shared renderer; birds are simple rigged meshes on spline flight paths with noise, plus behaviors (scatter, dive, flee, charge).
- Host-authoritative hits with lag compensation (rewind birds up to 150 ms) so shooting feels local; bird paths are deterministic from a seed so clients agree.
- Six players, about 40 birds in the air at most, small bandwidth.

- Guns are data: a mesh built from toy-gun parts (body, barrel, grip, slide, magazine, accessories) with the shared grey-and-red palette, so new guns are cheap.

Sound

Plastic: every gun has a toy click under its real sound (the pistol's zap is a beep and a crack). Ducks quack, geese honk, swans hiss, the phoenix shrieks, the UFO hums. The dog barks, sniffs, and laughs. The clubhouse is a jaunty piano loop during the intermission; the hunt is a chiptune march that speeds up each round. Slot machines ding; scratchers scratch; the Slop Shop has its own tacky jingle. A jackpot plays a fanfare everyone hears from the porch.

Data

fowlplay_guns.json , fowlplay_attachments.json , fowlplay_birds.json ,
fowlplay_rounds.json , fowlplay_gambling.json , fowlplay_slop.json ,
fowlplay_modes.json .

Build order

Stage	Work	Gate
1	The porch, the marsh, the Zapper, three bird types, rounds and tally, the dog	One player shoots ducks for 3 rounds and it feels right
2	Six stalls and multiplayer with hit credit; bots	Six players finish a match on LAN
3	The room: gun counter, the 15 real guns, attachments, money	Buying and swapping guns in 45 s works
4	The 15 fun guns; all birds; bonus waves	Every gun has a bird it's best at
5	Gambling: slots, scratchers, the mystery-gun machine	The house edge holds over 10,000 simulated pulls
6	The Slop Shop with every sabotage and its counter	A sabotaged player can always fight back
7	Modes, tokens, cosmetics, sound, internet play	All targets met

Balance targets

- A round-1 Zapper player shoots 6–9 birds; by round 10 a well-bought player shoots 20–30.
- The fun guns are fun, not best: each wins on one bird type and loses on another; none takes more than 15% of birds across a sample.
- Gambling loses money on average (8% edge) and wins the match about one time in ten for the player who leans on it.
- Sabotage costs about a third of a round's earnings and costs the target about a fifth of a round's birds.

Open questions for the designer

- ☐ Should shooting another player's gun knock it out of their hands (a stronger PvP edge), or stay cosmetic as written?
- ☐ Should the mystery-gun machine be able to dispense the Zapper (a duplicate, and a laugh)?
- ☐ Is the UFO in every match, or a rare event?
- ☐ Should money carry between matches as a profile bank, or reset each match as written?